Changing prevalence of coronary heart disease risk factors and cardiovascular diseases in men of a rural area of Crete from 1960 to 1991.

This study compares the prevalence of coronary heart disease (CHD), risk factors (RF), and cardiovascular diseases (CVD) among Cretan men from a rural area examined in 1960 and 1991. The study population consisted of 148 men in 1960 and 42 men in 1991 of the same age group (fifty-five to fifty-nine years old) and from the same rural area. All men had a complete examination of the cardiovascular system and a resting electrocardiogram (ECG). Systolic BP (SBP) > or = 140 mmHg was found in 42.6% of the subjects in 1960 and in 45.2% in 1991 (NS). Diastolic BP > or = 95 mmHG was found in 14.9% of the subjects in 1960 as opposed to 33.3% in 1991 ($P < 0.02$). Total serum cholesterol (TSCH) > or = 260 mg/dL approximately 6.7 mmol/L) was found in 12.8% of the subjects in 1960 and in 28.6% in 1991 ($P < 0.01$). Heavy smokers (> or = 20 cigarettes/daily) were 27.0% in 1960 as compared with 35.7% in 1991 (:NS); 5.4% of the subjects in 1960 had light physical activity (PA) as compared with 14.3% in 1991 ($P < 0.01$); 74.7% of the subjects were farmers in 1960 as compared with 43.6% in 1991 ($P < 0.1$). The prevalence of CHD was 0.7% in 1960 as compared with 9.5% in 1991 ($P < 0.001$). Hypertensive heart disease was found in 3.4% of the subjects in 1960 and 4.8% in 1991 (NS). The prevalence of all major CVD was much higher in 1991 (19.1%) as compared with 1960 (8.8%) ($P < 0.01$). In conclusion, the prevalence of CHD RF and CVD was much higher in 1991 than in 1960 for Cretan men of the same age group. This higher prevalence seems to be related to dietary and life-style changes that have taken place in Crete during the last thirty years.